

An Ethnosemantic Study of Village Place Names

in the Songkhla Lake Basin

การศึกษาภูมินามหมู่บ้านลุ่มน้ำทะเลสาบสงขลาเชิงอรรถศาสตร์ชาติพันธุ์

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Received 19-05-2025

Revised 05-11-2025

Accepted 07-11-2025

Doi: 10.69598/artssu.2026.5176.

How to Cite:

Angsuwiriya, N., Chaipanit, P., & Petchaboon, C. (2026). An Ethnosemantic Study of Village Place Names in the Songkhla Lake Basin. *Journal of Arts and Thai Studies*, 48(1), E5176 (1-16).

Keywords: ethnosemantics, place names, Songkhla Lake Basin

คำสำคัญ: อรรถศาสตร์ชาติพันธุ์, ชื่อบ้านนามเมือง, ลุ่มน้ำทะเลสาบสงขลา

Abstract

Background and Objectives: Place names might be considered as linguistic evidence that contains the area's historical origin. An analysis of place names, hence, may result in further understanding local history. When combining such analysis with local interpretations of place names through their storytelling, this ethnosemantic study might reveal the historical depth and richness of the area that may be otherwise hidden in the explicit meaning of the place names.

Methods: This study is qualitative research that aims to explore and study the place names of the villages along the Songkhla Lake Basin, Songkhla province, across 4 districts, 56 communities, and 150 villages with the linguistic concept of ethnosemantics. The study was carried out through interviews with local community leaders.

Results: The research findings revealed the structures of village names in both single and compound structures. The most prevalent was a two-semantic composition, which included both the head words and the modifiers, particularly the key word in words such as Bo, Phang, and Tha. The most prevalent way of naming was to refer to natural phenomena, places, or important people. Finally, the reflection obtained from the naming indicated that the majority of people practice Buddhism and other religions that coexisted in the area, specifically Islam. In addition, the Chinese population emerged as the most prominent in the area. Furthermore, ways of life and occupations can be discerned from naming, which illustrates the diversity of people's lives, including rice farming, orchard keeping, fishing, and so forth. This reflects the demographical richness in the area and may be linked to the prosperity of the Suvannabhumi region as inferred from an analysis of place names.

Applications of this Study: The research findings could be synthesized into knowledge for the local people, enabling them to appreciate the significance of their regional resources and to eventually foster the conservation of these resources in the future.

Conclusion: The research on village names in the coastal districts of Songkhla province (Mueang Songkhla, Ranot, Sathing Phra, and Singhanakorn) reveals that naming practices reflect the region's geography, history, culture, and natural environment. Most villages are named after natural features, such as water-related terms like Bo, Phang, and Tha, indicating the area's strong connection to water. Naming after natural phenomena is the most common strategy, followed by names rooted in historical events, important individuals, or nearby landmarks like temples. The influence of Buddhism is particularly notable as many village names reflect Buddhist stories and practices, even in religiously diverse areas. Ethnic diversity, especially the presence of Chinese communities, also plays a role in naming traditions, reflecting Songkhla's historical origins. Additionally, village names often reflect the agricultural lifestyle of locals, referencing occupations like farming and fishing, as well as local flora. Thus, these naming patterns can indicate the cultural and environmental identity of the population in the Songkhla Lake Basin.

บทคัดย่อ

ที่มาและวัตถุประสงค์: ชื่อบ้านนามเมืองอาจถือเป็นหลักฐานทางภาษาที่บอกความเป็นมาทางประวัติศาสตร์ของพื้นที่ การวิเคราะห์ชื่อบ้านนามเมืองจึงอาจนำมาซึ่งความเข้าใจเกี่ยวกับประวัติศาสตร์ท้องถิ่น เมื่อผนวกการวิเคราะห์นี้เข้ากับการตีความของผู้คนในท้องถิ่นที่ผ่านการเล่าที่มาของชื่อ การศึกษาชื่อบ้านนามเมืองแบบอรรถศาสตร์ชาติพันธุ์ อาจเผยให้เห็นความลุ่มลึกทางประวัติศาสตร์ที่มีมากกว่าความหมายโดยตรงของชื่อเรียก

วิธีการศึกษา: การวิจัยนี้เป็นการวิจัยเชิงคุณภาพ เพื่อสำรวจและศึกษาชื่อบ้านนามเมืองในหมู่บ้านในบริเวณลุ่มน้ำทะเลสาบสงขลา จังหวัดสงขลา ทั้งสี่อำเภอ 56 ชุมชน และ 150 หมู่บ้าน ผ่านแนวคิดทางภาษาศาสตร์ที่เรียกว่าอรรถศาสตร์ชาติพันธุ์ ขั้นตอนการเก็บข้อมูลกระทำผ่านการสัมภาษณ์ผู้นำชุมชนในบริเวณเป้าหมาย

ผลการศึกษา: ผลการศึกษาเผยให้เห็น โครงสร้างชื่อบ้านนามแบบโครงสร้างเดียวและโครงสร้างผสม รูปแบบที่โดดเด่นมากที่สุด คือการผสมแบบสององค์ประกอบทางอรรถศาสตร์ ซึ่งรวมทั้ง คำหลัก (head words) และส่วนขยาย (modifiers)

เข้าด้วยกัน เห็นได้จากคำเช่น บ่อ พัง ท่า ฯลฯ วิธีการตั้งชื่อที่โดดเด่นมากที่สุด คือวิธีการตั้งชื่อตามปรากฏการณ์ทางธรรมชาติ สถานที่ หรือบุคคลสำคัญ ผลสะท้อนคิดจากการศึกษาการตั้งชื่อนี้ แสดงให้เห็นว่า ประชากรในพื้นที่นับถือศาสนาพุทธเป็นจำนวนมาก และนับถือศาสนาอื่นๆ ที่ดำรงอยู่อย่างสันติในพื้นที่ โดยเฉพาะอย่างยิ่งศาสนาอิสลาม นอกจากนี้ ประชากรเชื้อสายจีนเป็นกลุ่มที่โดดเด่นที่สุดในพื้นที่ จากการศึกษารายชื่อบ้านนามเมืองแบบบรรดาศาสตร์ชาติพันธุ์พบว่าชีวิตและอาชีพในท้องถิ่นยังสื่อผ่านการตั้งชื่อ สิ่งนี้แสดงถึงความหลากหลายของวิถีชีวิตของผู้คนในพื้นที่ เช่น การทำนา ทำสวน ทำประมง ฯลฯ สิ่งนี้สะท้อนให้เห็นถึงความมั่งคั่งของประชากรในท้องถิ่น และอาจเชื่อมโยงไปถึงความมั่งคั่งในดินแดนสุวรรณภูมิที่มาจากการวิเคราะห์ชื่อบ้าน

การประยุกต์ใช้: ผลจากการศึกษานี้ สามารถนำไปสังเคราะห์องค์ความรู้เพื่อคนในพื้นที่ ส่งเสริมให้ผู้คนมีความชื่นชมใน ความสำคัญของทรัพยากรท้องถิ่น และนำไปสู่การอนุรักษ์แหล่งทรัพยากรเหล่านี้ในอนาคต

บทสรุป: การวิจัยชื่อหมู่บ้านบริเวณที่ลุ่มน้ำทะเลสาบสงขลา จังหวัดสงขลา (อำเภอเมืองสงขลา, อำเภอระโนด, อำเภอ สทิงพระ และอำเภอสทิงพระ) แสดงให้เห็นว่า การตั้งชื่อนั้นสะท้อนถึงภูมิศาสตร์ ประวัติศาสตร์ วัฒนธรรม และ สิ่งแวดล้อมทางธรรมชาติของพื้นที่ดังกล่าว หมู่บ้านส่วนใหญ่ถูกตั้งชื่อตามลักษณะทางธรรมชาติ เช่น การใช้คำเกี่ยวกับ แหล่งน้ำ เช่น บ่อ ปาง และท่า เป็นต้น แสดงให้เห็นถึงความผูกพันต่อแหล่งน้ำของชุมชน การตั้งชื่อตามปรากฏการณ์ทาง ธรรมชาติเป็นอีกหนึ่งกลยุทธ์ที่พบได้บ่อย ตามมาด้วยกลยุทธ์การตั้งชื่อตามเหตุการณ์ทางประวัติศาสตร์ บุคคลสำคัญ หรือสถานที่สำคัญที่อยู่ใกล้เคียง เช่น วัด ฯลฯ อิทธิพลของศาสนาพุทธปรากฏเห็นได้อย่างชัดเจน เนื่องจากหลายหมู่บ้าน ปรากฏการเล่าเรื่องเกี่ยวกับศาสนาพุทธและการนับถือศาสนาพุทธ แม้ว่าในพื้นที่ดังกล่าวจะมีความหลากหลายทางศาสนา ก็ตาม ความหลากหลายทางชาติพันธุ์ โดยเฉพาะอย่างยิ่งในชุมชนชาวจีน มีส่วนสำคัญในธรรมเนียมการตั้งชื่อบ้านนาม เมือง สิ่งนี้สะท้อนให้เห็นถึงประวัติศาสตร์ความเป็นมาของจังหวัดสงขลา นอกจากนี้ หมู่บ้านต่าง ๆ มีชื่อที่สะท้อนวิถีชีวิต ทางเกษตรกรรมของคนในท้องถิ่น สืบเนื่องจากการอ้างอิงถึงอาชีพ เช่น การทำไร่ ทำนา หรือการหาปลา และชื่อของพืช พรรณท้องถิ่นต่าง ๆ ดังนั้น รูปแบบของการตั้งชื่อนี้สามารถบ่งบอกอัตลักษณ์ทางวัฒนธรรมและสิ่งแวดล้อมของประชากร บริเวณลุ่มน้ำทะเลสาบสงขลาได้

Introduction

The southern region of Thailand, in which the Songkhla Lake Basin is situated, is a region rich in fascinating narratives about its history. Owing to its geographical proximity to the sea, it served as a convenient transportation route for maritime trade in the Malay Peninsula known as the Golden Khersonese (the Golden Peninsula) in Ptolemy's *Geographia*. Thus, archeological and historical inquiries have long considered it as part of the Suvarnabhumi territories of the Southern Asian Peninsula. The Suvarnabhumi territories are widely recognized as a region of abundance and prosperity. While archeologists and historians may find their evidence buried deep in the earth or ancient manuscripts in the archives, our present research focuses on these traces of past wealth evident in the village names.

Toponymy appears to be a lesser-known subdivision of onomastics (a broader and more general field of the study of names). Toponym refers to a "place name," while toponymy is defined as "the study of linguistic designations for places and other aspects of geographical reference" (Hymes, 1964 as cited in Gainey, 1984 : 36). As Hymes (1964 as cited in Gainey, 1984 : 36) mentioned that the interest in place names is often one of historical or local curiosity seen in a question such as "How did that place ever get to be called เส้าไห้ /saw⁴ haj²/?", or "Why is this area called บางบ่อ /baaŋ boo¹/ when one sees only canals and rice fields about?". Thus, historical or local interest, in our case concerning Suvarnabhumi's ancient wealth, should be taken into the account when studying place names.

The previous attempts to extract and unpack in the meaning of Thai place names as culture specifics have been done under various theoretical frameworks and exhibit a range of data collection methods. For example, an effort to collect and analyze the temple names in Thailand by Nakhon Sawan Rajabhat University's Office of Arts and Culture resulted in *Tonchaophraya Watwanukrom* (2019, as cited in Prommas, 2022). Many researchers conducted fieldworks by interviewing the locals and categorized the names into groups to reach a conclusion or support their observation about the specific cultures in their studies (Prommas, 2022; Ruangsong, 2021). The latter conducted interviews with local people and categorized the naming into nine groups according to the prominent themes such as the naming of the temples after existing places, plants, geographical features, and important events, and offered an observation on the studied area's

values and cultures of the local people as reflected through their temple names. However, the study is not supported by any theoretical frameworks nor statistical interpretation. Similarly, the former studied the temple names using the same method but slightly asserted a linguistic aspect through categorizing the names into eight linguistic origins used in the temple naming such as Thai, Khmer, Sanskrit, Pali, Pali-Sanskrit, and other languages. Deelert et al. (2021) also studied the toponyms of temples in the Nakhon Chai Si district of Nakhon Pathom province, using the data gathered from in-depth interviews. The research findings indicated that the linguistic word structure ranges from one to three words, with certain geographical words being more prevalent than others. The locals' way of life and beliefs were then concluded by the researchers. Although the two 2021 studies both used the term toponyms when they added some linguistic aspects, they lacked appropriate linguistic theories that should underpin the studies for a more nuanced analysis. This presents a gap in the research that the present research aims to close.

Numerous studies have employed the concept of linguistic concept such as ethnosemantics, and their research findings show different linguistic aspects. Nevertheless, the researchers conveyed the interest in both the linguistic structures and narratives about the place origins and past prosperity, which could effectively reflect the background, ways of life, and cultures prevalent in the area. Supich & Pewporchai (2021) observed that place naming can be studied under the ethnolinguistic framework. They claimed that there are nine distinct categories of village naming in Ubon Ratchathani province: naming after geographical features, which was the most prevalent, followed by, for example, naming after plants or animals, important people, and religions and legends. These findings reflect the locals' culture in the aspects of village location, kinship, beliefs and religion. Another research that applied ethnosemantics is a study by Sawangsri & Surin (2022). The data (the names of accommodations in Varanasi, India) was collected from Google Maps, showing a single word structure (for example, Krishna Hotel and Varanasi Hotel) as well as an extended or multi-word structure (for example, Phra Nang Radha and Sawasdee Varanasi Hotel). There were eight meaning circles, encompassing those related to rituals, auspiciousness, nature, characteristics, and properties.

The pioneer study of place names in Songkhla, though not discernibly underpinned by ethnolinguistics, was conducted by Manoch Dinlansagoon (2013). The researchers collected the locals' narratives or their life stories about village and community names in the Songkhla Lake Basin in both Songkhla and Phattalung provinces. The researchers observed that the ways of life of the people are deeply rooted in traditional beliefs concerning their revered entities such as ancestors, gods, and spirits. Following Dinlansagoon's suggestion, this research applies the concept of semantic theory to elucidate the process of naming, instead of relying on the categorization of naming alone. While Dinlansagoon's fieldwork may be more extensive, hence resulting in 158 narratives, we focused only on the coastal regions of the Songkhla Lake Basin, and on the locals' narratives about their past prosperity. The present study's application of the ethnosemantic approach is not only different from previous studies but will provide a more systematic linguistic analysis of meaning for folk interpretations. The research findings, in addition to contributing the toponymic knowledge of the area, also resulted in the compilation of stories for the benefit of future studies that aim to uncover the regional wealth once observed as the Golden Peninsula in the ancient world.

Research Objectives

This research aims to identify and discuss the ethnosemantic aspect of village names along the Songkhla Lake Basin in the local people's narratives about the origin of their places and the past prosperity.

Research Methods

The present study is a qualitative study underpinned by an ethnosemantic framework, examining the place names of villages and communities along the Songkhla Lake Basin. The data is in a form of narratives recounted by the locals residing in the inquired village or community about its origin and association with its wealth. Below is the fieldwork area, which includes 4 districts and every village in the 4 districts according to the administrative divisions of Songkhla province that are adjacent to the high seas or the waters that flow into the Gulf of Thailand.

1. Singhanakorn district: 10 villages in Ching Kho sub-district, 8 villages in Wat Khanun sub-district, 8 villages in Hua Khao Sub-district, 10 villages in Muang Ngam sub-district, totaling 4 sub-districts and 36 villages.

2. Sathing Phra district: 7 villages in Cha Ting Phra sub-district, 7 villages in Kradangnga sub-district, 5 villages in Sanam Chai sub-district, 8 villages in Di Luang sub-district, 7 villages in Chumphon sub-district, 6 villages in Wat Chan sub-district, 6 villages in Bo Daeng sub-district, 6 villages in Bo Dan sub-district, totaling 8 sub-districts and 52 villages.

3. Ranot district: 5 villages in Khlong Daen sub-district, 10 villages in Tha Bon sub-district, 5 villages in Bo Tru sub-district, 6 villages in Pak Trae sub-district, 7 villages in Rawa sub-district, 4 villages in Wat Son sub-district, totaling 6 sub-districts and 43 villages.

4. Mueang district: 56 communities in Bo Yang sub-district, 10 villages in Khao Rup Chang sub-district, 9 villages in Ko Tao sub-district, totaling 3 sub-districts, 19 villages and 56 communities¹.

The snowball method was chosen for this research because it is the most effective method in reaching the informants within closely-knit communities such as ones along the Songkhla Lake Basin. The researchers aimed to interview at least one initial informant (seed) about the history of the village name, changes in the village name, and the cultural meaning that the informant can provide. As part of the criteria for informant selection, the initial informant needed to hold a position as a community leader and be highly knowledgeable about the stories within their own community. The researchers first inquired about this information from government agencies before contacting the community leaders, such as monks, imams, religious leaders, government officials, village headmen, or folk artists. The researchers then verified the information through documentary analysis and cross-referencing among informants in the same area, and by comparing the information with relevant documents and online sources.

The researchers presented an ethics form to clarify the procedures involved in data provision and requested informants to sign in acknowledgment of the research data collection. We then recorded and transcribed the voices into written texts and analyzed them in the form of narratives while ensuring the confidentiality of the participants' identities, by informing the informants that they had the right to withdraw from providing information at any time. Once the interviews were complete, the researchers transcribed and analyzed the meanings according to the linguistic structural components of the locals' conceptual framework (folk worldview). To ensure the validity of the data, the researchers also gathered data regarding the historical context of villages to analyze the toponymic elements in adjacent to the informants' narratives. As this analysis is underpinned by the ethnosemantics theory, the following section will elaborate about it for clearer view. In addition, when a tonal shift affects the meaning of a word, an IPA notation will be provided at the end of the word. Similarly, when Thai or other foreign words are analyzed from an ethnolinguistic perspective, they will be italicized.

¹Villages are communities located outside of municipal areas. In this context, this distinction is based on administrative boundaries. Therefore, if a settlement is within a municipal area, the term "communities" is used.

Conceptual Framework

In the field of linguistics, a name is defined as a word that does not provide an explanation for why a particular entity is designated by that name. Hence, it has an arbitrary quality. For instance, there may be no rationale for the word “morning” being used to refer to the time when the sun rises. Radding & Western (2010 : 395) suggested that this encompasses words pronounced in other languages that we are unable to elucidate the reasons behind their specific pronunciations. Therefore, a name encompasses more significance than merely a single word; for instance, the name of a city may convey more than just its geographical position. The act of naming thus carries particular cultural significance, for example, the telling of a story behind the meaning of a name. Hence, toponymy is the study of language that is inevitably interrelated to the lives of people within their respective communities (Radding & Western, 2010 : 410).

To study the naming of villages from a linguistic perspective, an ethnoscience approach was employed to ensure research rigor. Ethnoscience is a science that is based on reliability, validity, and exhaustiveness within the field of ethnography. The objectives of ethnography encompass the practices and descriptions of culture. The significance of the study of ethnography includes ethnological and comparative aspects, including cross-cultural comparisons (Sturtevant, 1964 : 123). Such combination between ethnology and semantics results in ethnosemantics.

Ethnosemantics is a combination of two theoretical frameworks: semantics is a linguistic study of meaning, whereas ethnology focuses on a group of people who share similar physical characteristics, language, and culture. Sharifian (2014 : 99) noted that “Cultural linguistics has also found strong common ground with cognitive anthropology.” Regarding the relationship between language and culture, ethnosemantics is regarded as a method that distinguishes between culture and knowledge in the organization of data. Consequently, ethnosemantics refers to the examination of the meaning of words within a language as a means to reflect the culture of a particular ethnicity. The majority of ethnosemantic research generally studies names of relatives, colors, people, places, foods, or plants (Charunrochana, 2016 : 148-149). Ethnosemantics is defined as a part of ethnolinguistics that employs a scientific study approach and is characterized by systematic methodology. Ethnosemantics also aids in comprehending the perspectives of villagers, which is a crucial aspect of understanding the human cognitive system as it is generally conducted to gain insight into the knowledge and cognitive frameworks of villagers or tribes through the examination of their languages.

Research with similar aims has occasionally been referred to as ethnoscience, the new ethnography, or ethnographic semantics. Such studies are based on the belief that language serves as a reflection of the thoughts and worldviews held by its speakers. Consequently, an analysis of the meanings associated with different categories of words within the language of a specific tribe will also uncover the thoughts and worldviews held by that tribe (Prasithrathsint, 1986). The fundamental understanding of ethnosemantics consists of two levels: global knowledge and indigenous knowledge. While the two levels of knowledge may appear distinct, ethnosemantics serves as a field that bridges them by examining folk wisdom through a scientific method. This method scientifically probes into the study of traditional Thai knowledge, facilitating its presentation, dissemination, transmission, and ongoing development (Prasithrathsint et al., 2012 : 25-26).

A pioneer scholar who was influential to ethnosemantics is an American anthropologist, Charles Frake. His work, along with other approaches in folk analysis, frequently focuses on the names of colors, diseases, animals, and plants. Some good examples of early works that paved the way for ethnosemantics include the studies conducted by Conklin (1964), which examined color names in the Hanunu language; Frake (1961), which investigated disease names in the Subanun language; and Frake (1962) which studied food names using a similar method. The primary principle of folk

classification was the concept of contrast and inclusion. Words that differ in comparison will be positioned at the same level, while those at a lower level will be included within words at a higher level. For instance, the terms “dog” and “cat” will be categorized equally, yet both will be under the umbrella of the animal terms.

Following Sturtevant’s method (1964 : 101-111), the principles can be divided into six types: (1) etics and emics refer to universal culture-general traits and culturally specific characteristics, respectively; (2) domains refer to the structure of word groupings in systematic classification; (3) terminology and terminological systems are the cognitive qualities or beliefs of people who use language to assign meaning to words; (4) paradigms and componential analysis are the processes of analyzing semantic components and differences in semantic characteristics in order to develop rules for distinguishing word meanings; (5) taxonomies are the search for folk traits through the classification of word differences, which could be sorted in order of difference; and (6) discovery procedures are the rationality in explaining meanings based on the study hypothesis by grouping and classifying the cultural variables under consideration.

The main principles used in ethnosemantics data analysis, according to Prasithrathsint et al. (2012) are as follows: (1) the analysis of words or languages for comprehending the villagers’ concepts, leading to insight into their knowledge systems, ways of thinking, and cultural practices; (2) data used in the analysis must be obtained naturally and objectively; (3) language analysis should focus on the meaning of words; (4) the analyst should use scientific methods that can be verified; and (5) the main objective of word-meaning analysis is to reveal the knowledge system from the villagers’ perspective, rather than the analyst’s perspective. The current research is influenced and underpinned by the aforementioned principles. Based on the concept of ethnosemantics mentioned above, the researchers analyzed the semantic components derived from the locals’ interpretations. Furthermore, the stories and narratives provided by the informants reflect the locals’ perspective on the elements of folk culture that lead to the naming of the village. This approach reveals a linguistic structural classification featuring head words and modifiers, analyzed according to the semantic elements that will be discussed in the following section.

Research Results

Out of 150 villages and 56 communities, the present research was able to compile a substantial number of narratives about the origin of their places and the past prosperity along the Songkhla Lake Basin. When the analysis was performed in accordance with the linguistic structure and the interviewees’ narratives based on the principles of ethnosemantics, the researchers could examine the structure of village and community names as primary and component terms by removing prefixes, namely, the word ban (house) which is placed before a village name and the word chum chon (community) which is placed before Bo Yang sub-district because it is in the Songkhla Municipality area. As a result, specific prefixes or starting words would appear. Both ban and chum chon were removed. The researchers were interested in evaluating the names after these words to see how they would be named; however, if ban was placed after chum chon, ban was also analyzed.

1. Structures of Village Names

The research findings identified two key structural characteristics: a single word and a compound structure. The latter is comprised of a main composition with an extension that can be positioned both in front of or behind the main composition. The least prevalent structure was the three-word compound structure.

A single word structure includes words that convey meaning about places, trees, animals, people's names, places, stories, and new names, as in the following examples.

Religious places: Chedi Ngam, Sai Khao, and Kubor
 Trees: Hua Nod, Muang Phum, Muang Ngam, and Liap
 Animals: Don Yae, Matcha, and Khi Nak
 Persons: Ta Luang Kong and (Phang)Thera
 Places: Pa O, (Ban)Nok, (Ban)Bon, and Tha Khao
 Stories: Chumphon, Chai Khueng, Pratu Khian, and Phakho
 New names: Mueang Mai Phatthana, Sin Paiboon, and Phiset Police Station

These terms are sorted and categorized as head words and modifiers

Table 1 The Semantic Composition of Village Names in the Forms of Head Words and Modifiers

Semantic Structure	
Head Word	Modifier
Bo	Po / Tia / Glong
Phang (Traphang)	Khi Teng / Yang / Ped
Khlong	Dan / Cha Nuan
Nong	Hoi
Wat	Nang Lao / Krachai Talay
Suan	Phra Nitet / Mak
Tha	Khao / Sa-arn / Khen / Bon
Marp	Prue / Bua
Laem	Son Aon / Sai

Table 2 The Semantic Composition of Words in the Forms of Modifiers and Head Words

Semantic Structure	
Head Word	Modifier
Sam	Bo
Nai	Marp
Nok	Suan
Hua	Khlong

The tables show that there are many words with water-related meaning such as Bo, Phang, Khlong, Nong, Tha, Marp, and Laem. The most frequently recurring words include Bo, Phang, Khlong, and Tha, respectively. The word Bo in particular indicates human agency in creating such geographical change that leads to the naming, while the rest are words for naturally occurring sources of water. The compound composition includes modifiers which are words related to animals (such as ducks or mollusks), trees (Bodhi, lotus, or rubber trees), historical figures (such as Nang Lao and Phra Nitet), and geographical location (such as Nai for inside and Nok for outside).

As to the compound composition, the mechanism of word construction was examined and showed that the village names have two to three-word structure. Multi-word structure is uncommon and found most frequently in Mueang district's village names than in other areas, for example (Chum Chon) Lang Tamnak Khao Noi, (Chum Chon) Lang Wittayalai

Archiwa, (Chum Chon) Massayid Ban Bon, and (Ban) Sala Luang Lang. Furthermore, there was a word construction approach for indicating the source of newness or oldness in a certain region. Many areas that have relocated use the word kao (old) after the name of their former community, namely Ban Su Rao Kao, Chum Chon Bon Wua Kao, and Chum Chon Songkhla Kao Hospital. Any newly established areas will include the word mai (new) following the name, which was especially common in the Mueang district, namely Chum Chon Phatthana Mai.

From an ethnosemantic perspective, we can understand the meanings and folk interpretations derived from the structural composition of the head words used in naming villages. This indicates that community members name things or establish names based on what is immediately familiar to them. The resulting meanings, therefore, emphasize the understanding of their own local environment. For instance, if a particular type of trees is abundant in the area, that specific plant name is then used to name the village, such as Phang Kham, Phang Tam Sao, Bo Pho, and Ban Khae. Furthermore, historical tales and accounts also influence village naming, such as Phang Chang Tai (literally translated as “where the elephants died”). This village name comes from a past story where gold was transported from states in Malaysia and loaded onto elephants that had traveled a long distance. When they arrived at this spot, the elephants collapsed and died. The elephants, having traveled for many days, might have been ill and failed to reach Nakhon Si Thammarat, which was the significant destination for people of that era who sought to use valuable goods to help build the stupa (chedi). Local residents believe that if one were to dig thoroughly in the area where the goods fell and buried, they would likely find the elephant bones, and perhaps the gold.

The findings of the place names believed to be part of the Suvarnabhumi region show that the areas were prosperous in the three aspects, namely natural resources, religions and cultures, and material wealth. As a result, it was expected that the naming groups and narratives shared by the locals would embody the knowledge related to these regional prosperities.

2. Groups of Naming

The research results can be classified into 4 groups, based on the findings from 4 areas, with the resulting percentages presented as follows:

Table 3 The Semantic Composition of Words in the Forms of Modifiers and Head Words

Groups of Naming	Natural Phenomena		Existing Places		Persons		Beliefs and Stories	
	Names	%	Names	%	Names	%	Names	%
Ranot District	22	12%	6	3%	3	2%	7	4%
Sathing Phra District	22	12%	7	4%	4	2%	9	5%
Singhanakorn District	12	7%	16	9%	5	3%	6	3%
Mueang District	12	7%	31	18%	1	1%	5	3%

The researchers counted the instances of the aforementioned names across all communities and villages, excluding 29 communities that represented newly demarcated areas within the Mueang District municipality. This exclusion was made because these were new designations assigned by government agencies for convenience, using modern naming styles (e.g., Chukiat Village, Kankheha Village, etc.), which are typical of housing estates in newly established communities. Consequently, a total of 177 community and village names remained for analysis. The statistical data revealed that names categorized as “Natural Phenomena” were prevalent further away from urban areas, while “Existing Places” were observed more frequently within the city limits. Next, the 4 groups of village and community naming are analyzed.

2.1 Natural Phenomena

This group is commonly found in rural or remote areas, such as Ranot district and Sathing Phra district, which have 22 names each, and Singhanakorn district and Mueang district, which have 12 names each (see Figure 1). Examples of names in this group are as follows: (1) names related to plants and trees, such as Makham Klan /ma³-kha:m⁴-khla:n/, which originates from the tamarind tree, Bo Pho (bɔ:¹-pho:) from the Bodhi tree, Liap /liap²/ from the Liap tree, Pang Sai /phaŋ-saj/ from the banyan tree, or Ban Kae /ban²-khɛ:/ from the Kae tree; (2) names related to animals, such as Nong Hoi /nɔ:ŋ⁴-hɔ:j⁴/, which originates from the place with a lot of shellfish (hoi), Ban Khi Nak /ba:n²-khi:²-na:k²/ from a large number of otters (nak) that excreted there, Khlong Ped /khɔ:ŋ-pet¹/ from Nai Rang (the man named Rang, the same legend as Kao Seng) raising ducks (ped) in the canal, or Don Yae /dɔ:n-jɛ:³/ from butterfly lizard (yae); and (3) names related to natural characteristics, namely Bo Daeng, which originates from the red color (daeng) of the water dredged up from the pond, Plai Khlong, from the end, head, or front of the canal (khlong) that roots from the canal's terminus, Phang Luek, from the area with deep (luek) water because the word phang originates from Traphang that means a basin, pond, or swamp.

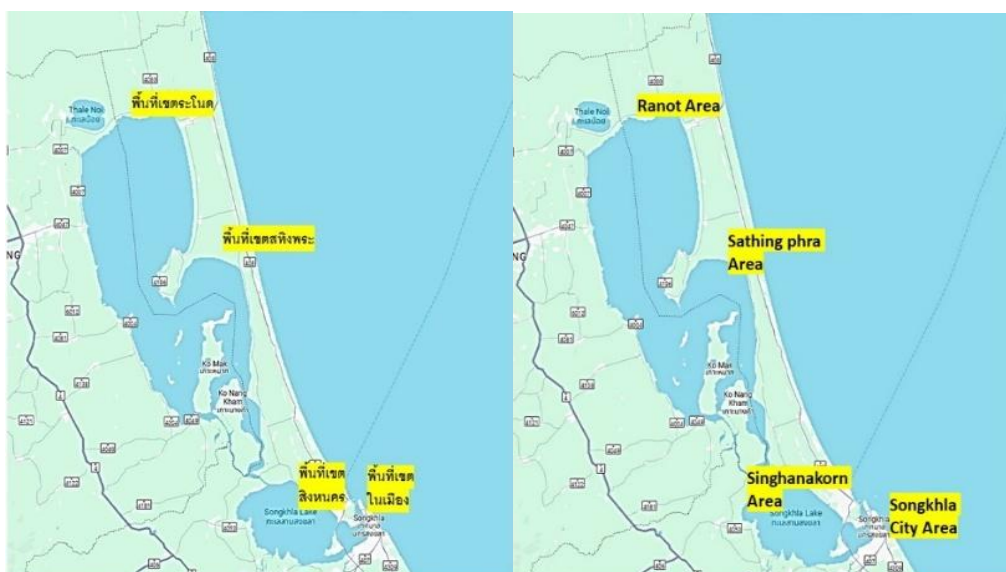


Figure 1 Map of Fieldwork Area in Songkhla Province
(Source: Modified Google Map Adapted by Angsuwiriya, 2024)

In addition, the historical evidence indicates that the Singhanakorn district was originally part of the Songkhla city area prior to the relocation of Mueang district to its present location in Bo Yang sub-district, Mueang district, Songkhla province. The name Singhanakorn originates from its historical association with Mueang district of Songkhla in ancient times. However, foreign maritime traders who came to Songkhla city, such as Persians, Indians, Arabs, and Sumatrans, observed the area from the sea and noted its resemblance to a lion (sing or singto in Thai). Consequently, they referred to it as Singhala, which was later mispronounced as Zingora. According to the royal judgment of King Rama V, this city was originally named Singhanakorn (nakorn means city, hence the city of lions); however, due to difficulties in pronunciation by foreigners, it was later pronounced differently (Encyclopedia of Thai Culture, Southern Region, 1999 : 7996). Thus, the names of the villages are quite similar, which is one of the explanatory remarks in the settlement and naming contexts that the areas in Mueang district and the areas far from Mueang district have distinct naming characteristics, as well as distinct concepts of nature.

2.2 Existing Places

This group is most commonly found in rural or remote areas, such as Ranot district (six names found), Sathing Phra district (seven names found), Singhanakorn district (16 names found), and Mueang district (31 names found). Below are examples from our findings.

Names related to places, such as temples, roads, or important places in such area, are used as village names, namely Wat Dee Luang /wat³-di:luang⁴/, which originates from the name of a temple (wat) in the village, Ban Chai Ku /ba:n²-cha:j-khu:/, from the old moat whose geography has since changed, and Chedi Ngam, from a remarkably beautiful (ngam) chedi.

We found that Mueang district's communities and villages mainly fall into this group. This may be primarily due to the expansion of Mueang district and its frequent rezoning activities. Whenever a rezoning occurred, a straightforward approach was to designate it after a nearby location, such as a temple, hospital, housing estate, or road, which can serve as a name for the community. To observe a new name, one could locate and identify a suffix that differentiates it from the original community's name, for example suffixes phatthana (development), samakkhi (collaboration), or mai (new) signify that the community has recently been established.

Names related to certain events can be found in, for example, Bo Dan /bɔ:¹-da:n./ The name comes from the community's scarcity of drinking water, so they dug up a well or a pond (bo) for underground water (dan). Bo Dan also indicates the reduction of word in the southern Thai dialect as the full word in central Thai is Bo Ba Dan (underground water pond). Phang Phao /phaŋ-phaw/, which originates from a ship that was anchored at this pond, is a shortening of the name Traphang to Phang, and Samphao (junk ship) to Phao. Ban Tha Khen /ba:n²-tha:²-khen⁴/ originates from the necessity to push small canal boats that may become caught on the sandbar onto a larger boat in the sea. Balaseh Kaosaen Community /chum-chon-ba:-la:-sɔŋ³-ka:w²-sɛ:n⁴/ originates from the Muslim community leader who chose the word balaseh, which means a place for Muslims to pray, as the name. The word kaosaen /ka:w²-sɛ:n⁴/ refers to Kao Seng Community /ka:w²-se: ŋ²/. This is the result of phonological change in the last syllable. This was influenced by the historical account about Nai Raeng who brought nine-hundred-thousand /ka:w²-sɛ:n⁴/ baht to fund the construction of chedi in Nakhon Si Thammarat. The sound /sɛ:n⁴/ was later changed to /se: ŋ²/.

2.3 Persons

The characteristics of naming the place after persons include historical figures associated with memorable events and generic nouns associated with human entities. There are few instances of this group: three names in Ranot district; 4 names in Sathing Phra district; five names in Singhanakorn district; and one name in Mueang district.

Names that result from misunderstandings might be due to mispronunciation or phonological change, such as Wat Nang Lao /wat³-na:ŋ-law²/. The place is named after a laywoman named Nang Lao who donated the land for the temple during King Narai's reign. The word lao /law²/, meaning alcohol, has undergone a phonological change with the word lao /la:w/, referring to the Lao ethnicity. The researchers observe that this phonological change makes it impossible to definitively identify the definition with its written form as the word lao (เหล้า /law²/ meaning alcohol), because the same pronunciation could also be spelled as “เล้า” (lao), which means “to tell.” Therefore, Nang Lao, who may have been of the Lao ethnicity, could correspond in meaning to either “เล้า” (/law²/ meaning to tell) or “เหล้า” (/law²/ meaning alcohol) because they are pronounced identically, differing only in their written form and meaning. However, the current written form used for the naming is “เหล้า” (/law²/), which means an alcoholic beverage. All informants giving the account about the origin of this place name reported that Ban Mai /ba:n²-maj¹/ was named after a Chinese man named Chao Mai, who was a king's grandson. This shows a phonological change from the word mai (ไหม /maj⁴/), meaning silk, to the word mai

(ใหม่ /maj¹/), meaning new. Such pronunciation change is another phonological change. Later, the temple in the area was named Wat Mai (new temple), but the landowner and builder of the temple still called it Wat Chao Mai. Three informants told similar stories adding small different details. For example, one informant talked about a Chinese man called Chao Mai who was given a Thai royal title, Mom Chao, hence later known as Chao Mai. Later, Chao Mai built a temple known as Wat Chao Mai, eponymous to the landowner's name. The next informant said that Ban Mai comes from Wat Mai and that Chao Mai was a wealthy Chinese man. Another informant gave a similar account about Wat Mai being built by a wealthy Chinese man, but in this variation, he was not given a Thai royal title; it was a regional custom to honor and refer to any wealthy Chinese persons as Chao Mai. The same practice is seen in Hat Chao Mai (a beach in Trang province also in the south of Thailand). Thus, the use of the word mai (new) might likely be used to modify the place than the person.

Bo Tia /bɔː¹-tia²/ was named after the Chinese word tia (father). This is because someone came across a pond and asked who owned it. The child said it was his father's pond. Later, it was shortened to Bo Tia (father's pond). All three informants giving the account about the origin of this place name reported the same story about the Chinese word tia /tia¹/, adding small different details. The first informant told a story about the pond being noticed by passersby who often asked about the owner and the children answered that it was their father's pond. Later it was called /bɔː¹-tia²/ with a tonal shift suggesting a characteristic accent of the southern Thai dialect. The second informant told a similar story but added a detail about the pond being dug by a Chinese who used the underground water for his moonshine business as he noticed that there were many laborers docked at the town. The last informant told a story about the place being full of ponds. Later, all but one pond was filled up, and that pond is Bo Tia.

Names after actual people, include Ta Luang Kong /taː-luaŋ⁴-khoŋ/, which originates from the name of an ancient person who shaped his future and also built this temple; Phang Chi /phaŋ-chiː/, which originates from a nun (Chi) who came to live in the reservoir area (traphang); Suan Phra Nithet Community /chum-chon-suan⁴-phaŋ³-ni³-thet²/, which originates from Phra Nithet (a nobleman from elsewhere), the owner of this garden (suan); and Phra Nithet, who is believed to be a Chinese ethnic nobleman who lived and owned the land in the area.

2.4 Beliefs and Stories

Based on villagers' beliefs and stories, Ranot district, Sathing Phra district, Singhanakorn district and Mueang district each has seven, nine, six and five village names, respectively. Such can be illustrated by the following examples.

In Ban Phang Tuad /ba:n²-phaŋ-thuat²/, the word phang originates from traphang (reservoir), where the people in the area frequently encountered the harmless huge snakes. Formerly, people believed the naming was about the great-grandfather, who is an angel (tewada). Later, the vowels in tewada were removed and the term became tuad (great-grandfather). Today, the land has been completely filled in. Beliefs in angels or sacred items have existed in the Southern region since the origin of Ban Phang Tuad. The majority of Southern Thais believe in the great-grandfathers, who are descended from snake-like animals and revered as angels.

Pratu Khian /pra¹-tuː-khian⁴/ originates from an old story, in which there was a forest populated with tigers. Some folks left their houses without notifying anybody and never came back since the tigers would eat them. The village thus displayed signs and recorded who went where and who came back when. For instance, Mr. A visited the beach for business and returned. If they visited the beach and not returned, a tiger might have eaten them. The village was thereafter called Ban Pratu Khian, as the word khian means to write or to record something, and the word pratu means door, hence the village of the written door. Informants gave the same account about Bang Phang Tuad and Prau Khian.

Samkong village /mu:¹-ba:n²-sa:m⁴-kɔ̌ : ɲ / originates from a historical account when there was a checkpoint and three military forces (sam kong) called three companies and three divisions, so it was called Samkong village. Informants gave account regarding the origin of this village, adding small details. For example, the first informant said that there were checkpoints at Samkong comprised of three military forces. Another informant added detail about ethnic diversity of the three military forces. The three military forces included soldiers from Laos, Vietnam and Songkhla formed into three forces. Other village names in Songkhla reflecting the ancient wars in many communities, include Chum Pho or Dan. Such stories reflect the setting of historic battles. They often describe the raising of armies and the establishment of armed forces; in turn they result in the place names representing the ethnic diversity of the people of Songkhla province.

From the naming of villages along the Songkhla Lake Basin, there are distinctive characteristics in the naming, such as naming after natural phenomena, existing places, persons, and beliefs and stories. As naming and renaming are processes that occur over the generations in the areas, they are prone to modification and alteration. The names used today have changed in many ways through, for example, misunderstandings or new interpretations by local people, which can be seen in their recounting of stories behind place names, or even later changes in tones, syllables, and words. This includes renaming to fit with government affairs. Although they are obligated to formalize the language, legends or historical accounts continue to be passed down. Even though the stories have been distorted throughout the passage of time, they still reflect the local people's cognitive investment in the naming. This demonstrates that changes in the sound or meaning of words come from the influence of local dialects (the cognitive system of the local people) and the bureaucratic system. All in all, they reveal people's thought system through language.

Discussion and Conclusion

1. Reflections on the Naming

The knowledge obtained from the naming of villages in the Songkhla Lake Basin using ethnosemantics emphasizes the concept of people in the community or region. As a result, the outcomes obtained are the interpretation of the people's understanding of the stories of their own village names.

1.1 The Influence of Buddhism

Upon examining the evidence related to the naming of villages, it becomes evident that the names are associated with various temples and the people who contributed funds for their construction. Additionally, there are stories regarding the establishment of pagodas, which is reflected in the naming of the villages, namely Kao Seng Community, a community that is renowned for the legend of Hua Nai Raeng. During the reign of King Sri Thammasokarat, who erected the pagoda at Nakhon Si Thammarat, Nai Raeng collected funds to construct the chedi. But when he arrived at the Songkhla River, he discovered that the chedi had already been completed. Nai Raeng was very depressed, and he drowned his boat carrying 900,000 baht of treasures. Later, it was distorted to Kao Seng. There is still a symbol of a stone that appears to fall from the cliff in the area. Ban Pho, which originates from Photi (or Bodhi), implies liberty. Religious faith led to the planting of Bodhi trees. Bodhi trees are now found everywhere. Although there were numerous Bodhi trees, the elderly villagers believed it came from just one. Moo Ban Phakho originates from an ancient mountain in the region called Phato, which was later distorted to Phakho. There was a chedi. And then Luang Pu Thuat came to develop the temple during the period of Phra Ekathotsarot, the city governor who believed in Buddhism and built a Buddha image named Phra Kothama. The villagers called this mountain Khao Phra Khotama. Wat Phra Khotama was distorted to Wat Phakho. Some said that Phakho originates from Phakhu or Phakho. Pha is water, and Khu is bright, which means totally the light of

blazing fire. It was changed its the vowel “U” to “O” and finally became Phakho, which means Luang Pu Thuat had the power to fly while the fire was blazing like a torch. Another explanation refers to Luang Pho Phra Kho Lo. In this interpretation, “Lo” is derived from the idea of attaining enlightenment. For this reason, villagers called him “Phakho Lo” to honor and recognize his spiritual attainment. Although the stories are slightly different, they mutually express the same notion regarding the story of Buddhism.

Consistent with historical evidence, the Southern peninsula became a settlement as late as the fifth Buddhist Century, influenced by both Srivijaya Kingdom and Tambralinga Kingdom before becoming independent in the 20th Buddhist Century, under the rule of Ayutthaya Kingdom to Rattanakosin Kingdom. These had temples as the community centers, especially in farmer communities, resulting in the spread of temples and eventually the strength of Buddhism (Buranaut & Kirdsiri, 2014: 16-17). This connection is reflected in the tales or legends of the construction of chedi, as well as in the meaning of the village names, such as Ban Pho and Ban Pha Kho, as illustrated in the examples above.

1.2 Religious and Belief Diversity

In addition to the strength that appears in the village names that reflect the image of Buddhism, there is also a diversity of beliefs and faiths in the area, especially Islam in the Songkhla Lake Basin, such as Ban Bon Mosque Community, Kubor Community and Kao Saen Balaseh Community, reflecting the group of people with the same beliefs living together. Moreover, elements of Brahmanism and Hinduism can be seen in local place names. For example, Pang Chi Village is believed to derive its name from the word “Brahman,” reflecting the influence of Brahmanism and Hinduism in the area. Similarly, Ban Phang Tuad is associated with beliefs in gods and angels. The word “Tuad” is thought to originate from “Thevada,” meaning deity or god. According to local legend, villagers once discovered unusually large snakes and referred to them as “Tuad,” connecting them symbolically to divine beings. This is a belief that the huge snake represents a god who protects and guards the village. This belief will prevent villagers from harming snakes, which is an indirect way to preserve the natural resource or the animals in this case. Similarly, in the case of Ban Suea Mueang, the word Suea Mueang refers to the city’s ancient guardian angel. Another example is found in the story about Ban Bo Glong: a Muslim man tied his cow to a tree and, upon passing the well, heard the sound of a drum echoing from inside. He bent down to look and saw a drum floating on the water. When he saw the drum sink back into the water, he turned to leave. However, the sound of the drum rang out again, and when he bent down to look, the drum was floating once more. Therefore, the place was named Bo Glong (Drum Well). It was a sacred well in ancient times, and anyone who was sick would take water from this well to drink and would be healed.

1.3 Ethnic Diversity

In addition to the original ethnic groups in the area, there are also other ethnic groups that played a key role in the story of naming villages in the Songkhla Lake Basin, especially the Chinese people who appear in many areas, such as Ban Phang Thia, a temple built by women. The word thia is a word used by the Chinese according to the villagers’ understanding. Similarly, the word tia in Ban Bo Tia originates from the word tia in Chinese. The Chinese ethnic group played a key role in the area. This location was a trading hub with many countries, especially China. Many communities in the area were influenced by the Thai-Chinese ethnic group. The naming of their villages were then influenced by Chinese culture and language. Yet, as time passed, these names underwent phonological change. For example, the locals in Ban Tin No /ba:n2 ti:n nɔ:/ told a story about the village’s old names, Ban Jin /ba:n2 ci:n/ or Ban Jin Non /ba:n2 ci:n nɔ:n/, which literally translated as “Chinese village” or “Village where the Chinese sleep”. In the past, many Chinese people boarded junks and docked in the area to trade with the locals. When night fell, they would sleep in the village; and this led to the village naming as Ban Jin Non. Later, the sounds in the names underwent phonological change from

Jin Non /ci:n nɔ:n/ to Tin No /ti:n nɔ:/ . Moreover, there are also stories of warfare, so armies from various ethnic groups came to the area, such as Ban Bo Sap. In Ban Bo Sap there is a story that Japan lost the war, and before returning, the Japanese soldiers buried their treasures here or divided themselves into several divisions. These circumstances are reflected in the names Ban Sam Kong, Ban Dan, and Ban Chumphon, as well as the village's name, Ban Sanam Chai, which was given to it after the war victory.

1.4 Ways of Life and Occupations

The names of the villages in the Songkhla Lake Basin reflect the ways of life and occupations of the people in the communities. The majority of them also reflected wealthy lifestyles. The naming was also associated with the past, as the place was a trading and economic center during the Suvannabhumi era, when its residents were wealthy and prosperous. The well-being can be reflected from the naming of the villages, namely Ban Ching Kho, Ban Plai Na, Ban Wat Bo Thong, Ban Bo Suan, Ban Bo It, Ban Hua Yang, Ban Matcha, Ban Pang Phao, Ban Hua Nod, Ban Hua Khlong, Ban Khlong Daen, and Ban Wat Krachai Thale. When we examined the naming of villages or communities in relation to geography, we discovered that the names contained a variety of abundant resources. These included forests, mountains, canals, and seas, along with ponds or reservoirs that facilitate convenient water usages, irrigation, and navigation in earlier times. Such observations can provide insights into the prosperity of these areas in the past. This is due to the fact that when transportation convenient, communication and trade also become more accessible.

Upon examining the stories about the village names, it is evident that treasure and wealth associated with the location of Suvannabhumi is one of the major themes. For instance, Kao Seng Community is primarily associated with Buddhism, while names such as Ban Bo Sap and Bo Thong signify the prosperity of the area in the past. Moreover, from the interview with the local people, some of the locals expressed their belief in the past prosperity and treasures through their use of words such as sap /sap³/, meaning wealth and thong /thɔ:ŋ/, meaning gold. The word thong is a synonym of Suvann, which is a loan word from Sanskrit (Suvanna सुवर्ण meaning good color or golden). Although the relationship of this area to Suvannabhumi, based on historical and archeological evidence, may still require further academic debate, the researchers' analysis of village naming shows that the area demonstrates geographical diversity, fertility, and captivating narratives about its history, particularly those concerning treasures associated with temple construction. Many temples can be found in the area where the researchers collected data, as evidenced by the widespread use of temple names as the village names. This reflects the locals' richness in the past as it would be impossible to build temples if people were struggling financially. Furthermore, ethnic variety, particularly the Chinese immigrants, also influenced the construction of temples in the region. These observations led us to construe that the valuable treasure from the past era along the Songkhla Lake Basin may have been Buddhism as well as the explicit meaning of treasure in terms of material and natural wealth.

2. Reflections on the Ethnosemantic Research

This study of naming found a relationship between the analysis of language in the linguistic aspect that reflects the cultural and historical stories, geography, and cognitive frameworks of the people in the area. This is consistent with other studies on a similar topic in the issue of naming after geography or terrain, people's names, histories, beliefs, values, cultures, locations, important places, important events, people's ways of life (Dinlansagoon, 2013; Jaiping & Kemkan, 2022; Prommas, 2022; Ruangsong, 2021). Although other studies found such consistent characteristics, they may differ from the present study in the theoretical concepts, since we focus on the linguistic concepts and the structures of languages. Both Deelert, Wiyaporn, and Phaetprida (2021) and our research found that the most prevalent structure for

naming consists of two words. While their study found the words *tha* and *huai* the most prevalent, our research found the words *bo* and *phang* (or *Traphang* in Standard Thai language) as the most prevalent. One explanation may be due to the coastal geography, where the local people must find an access to fresh water. Another speculation is that such village names starting with the word *bo* and *phang* may indicate their existence even before the pipeline system. The word *bo* in particular, was mentioned by the locals who nicknamed their village as the village of wells. This is due to the coastal geography where there is a scarcity of fresh water. The locals then need to dig up wells to access fresh water. Thus, the word *bo* recurs in many place names in the studied area, unlike other regions where fresh water is accessible, hence the words *huai* and *tha* recur most.

3. Conclusion

According to the research findings on reflections from the naming of coastal villages in the Songkhla Lake Basin, covering all 4 districts of Songkhla province, which are situated in coastal areas, namely Mueang, Ranot, Sathing Phra, and Singhanakorn, the researchers found some interesting semantic structure in the naming convention. Head words from categories such as trees, persons' names, or places as village names, are combined with modifiers, such as the words /bɔ̌ː/, /phaŋ/ and, /thaː˥˥/, which show the important characteristics of the area adjacent to the water. Upon studying the naming groups, it becomes apparent that naming after natural phenomena is the most prevalent. This may be attributed to the fact that three of the districts, with the exception of Mueang, continue to possess abundant natural resources and a long history since the Ayutthaya period. There are also naming after historical figures and generic noun associated with human entities. Another widespread usage of this group, particularly in the Mueang district, is to name communities or villages after nearby places of interest, particularly temples. Additionally, the influence of Buddhism is noticeable in the naming convention. The researchers found that the naming of communities or villages are more related to Buddhist stories and rituals, despite the fact that there is religious diversity in the areas, for example, Mueang district has many Muslim communities. Moreover, many areas show ethnic diversity through their names. As the local people have formed a stronger relationship with Chinese people than other nationalities, some names reflect Chinese ethnics. Finally, the naming of the villages, which reflect the lives of the local people whose occupations include farming, gardening, and fishing, as well as the names of various plants, demonstrate Songkhla province's agricultural abundance.

Acknowledgments

This research was funded by Prince of Songkla University's "Research Funding for Social Science Projects under the Thailand Academy of Social Sciences, Humanities and Arts (TASSHA)" [grant number: LIA6502122S]. The researchers would like to extend our gratitude to all participants for their invaluable insights, without which this research might not have been possible.

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